What makes a book popular and highly rated on Goodreads?

Exploratory analysis of the supplied Best Books Ever dataset

Executive conclusion

Popular records tend to be concentrated among established authors, widely represented genre tags, and records with series or award metadata. High rating averages are a separate outcome: popularity is only weakly related to scores, and perfect scores occur exclusively among very small samples. This analysis describes associations in the supplied dataset, not causal drivers or the current Goodreads catalog.

Data cleaning and definitions

Input: 52,478 rows and 23 fields. Removed 50 exact duplicates, trimmed text, then removed 44 repeated case-insensitive title/full-author pairs, keeping the record with the most ratings. Final dataset: 52,384 records. This is a pragmatic title-level approximation: different editions, translations and author-credit variants may remain, while same-title/same-author editions can be merged.

Popularity = numRatings (rating volume), not sales, unique readers, or Best Books Ever voting. Rating outcome = supplied rating, valid from 1 to 5 with at least one rating. Excluded 71 zero-rating records from score summaries, but retained them for coverage and popularity analyses. No score outliers were deleted.

Parsed genres, awards, characters, settings and star counts from serialized lists. Genre analysis explodes tags and counts each record once per tag. First-credited author is the text before the first comma, with the Goodreads Author badge removed. This heuristic may misclassify unusual name formats and does not allocate ratings among coauthors.

Converted pages and prices to numeric fields; removed the page suffix and treated nonpositive pages or negative prices as missing. Missing or invalid pages: 2,505; missing/unparseable prices: 14,340. No median imputation was used. Currency is unknown, so price is not used as an explanatory variable.

Preserved dates and ISBNs as supplied. Scientific-notation ISBNs have lost precision and are unsuitable identifiers. Mixed/ambiguous dates and suspicious years prevent reliable age-based analysis without external validation. Missing descriptions, languages, publishers and editions remain missing; absent series/award metadata is explicitly labeled not listed.

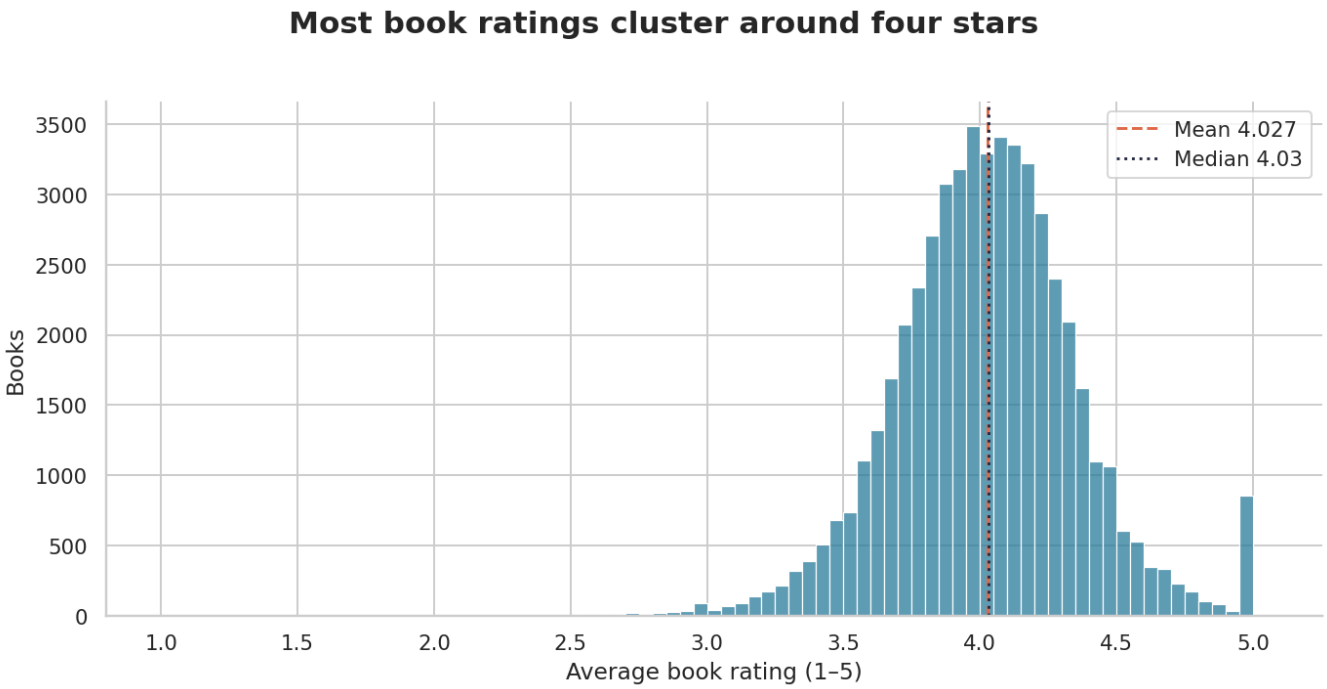
For 1,414 retained records the parsed five-star counts do not sum to numRatings. These records are retained, using supplied rating and numRatings consistently; star-derived measures are not used as outcomes. likedPercent and ratingsByStars are rating-derived, while bbeScore/bbeVotes are engagement measures, so none is treated as an independent explanation of quality.

Rating summary (one record, one vote in this summary)

Metric	Value
Rated records	52,313
Mean rating	4.027
Median rating	4.03
Minimum rating	1.00
Maximum rating	5.00
Standard deviation	0.336

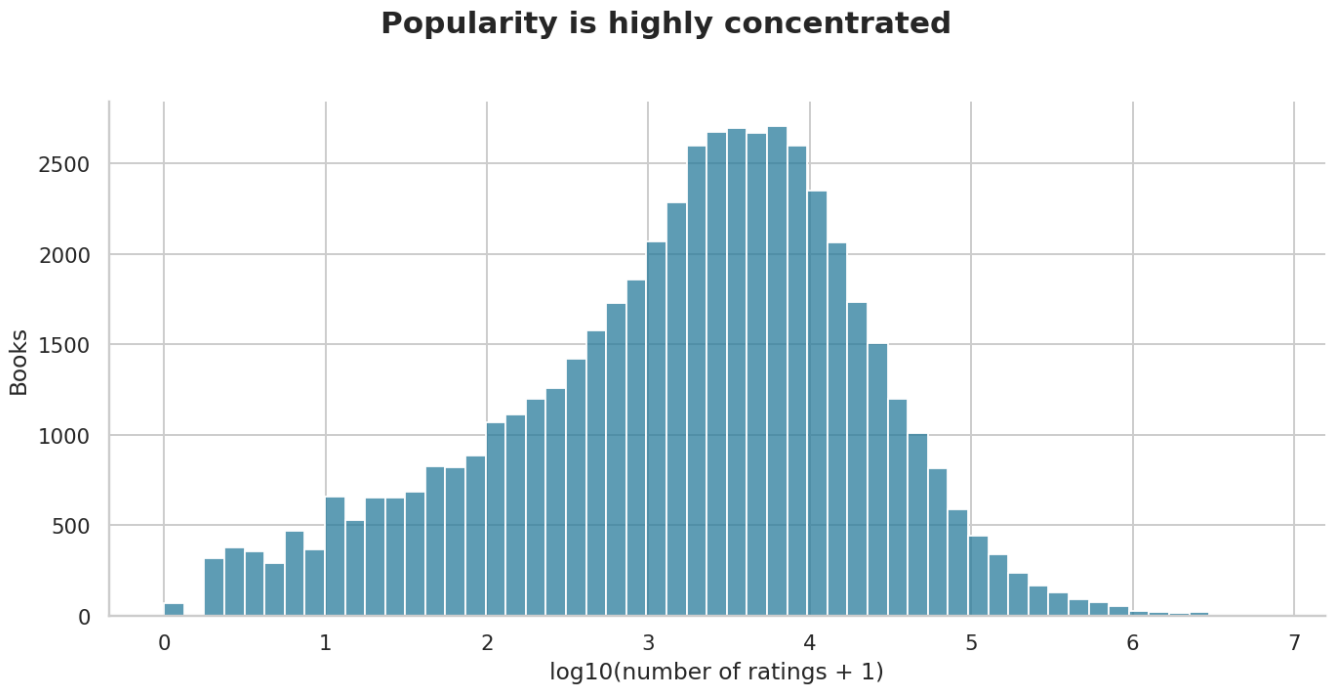
Ratings cluster near four stars

The mean is 4.027 and median 4.03; 88.6% of rated records fall between 3.5 and 4.5. Scores are concentrated, so small differences should not automatically be treated as meaningful quality differences.



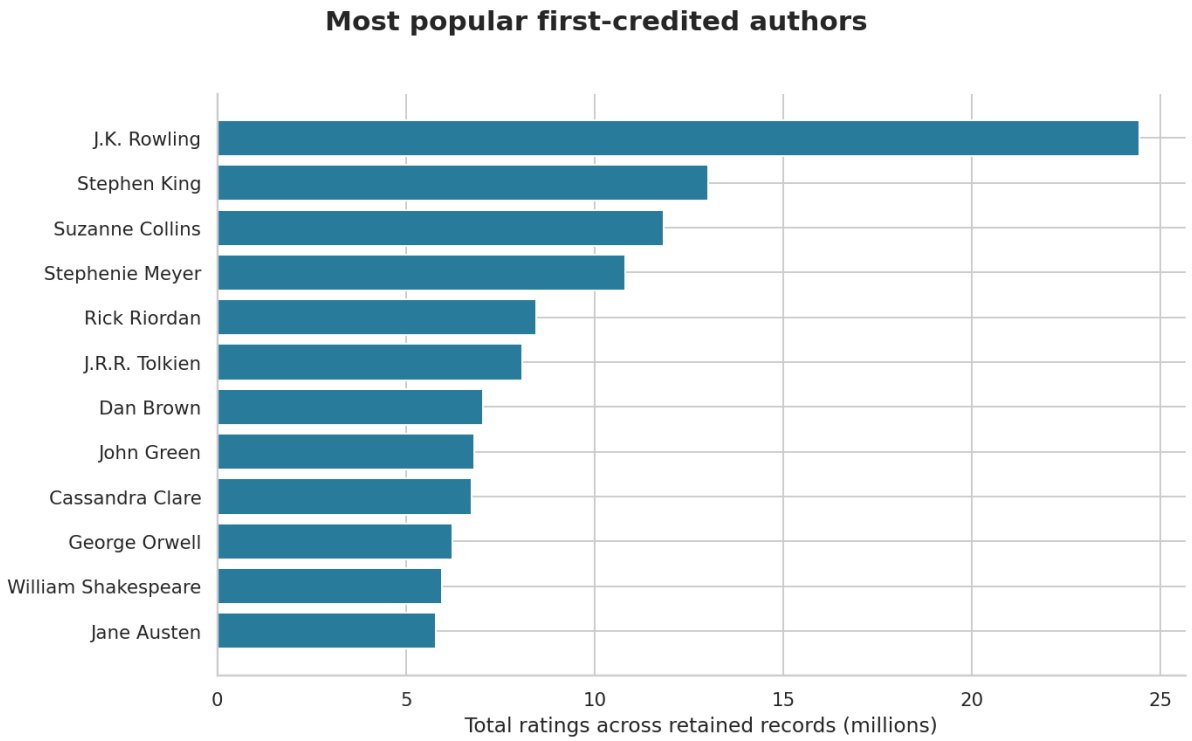
Popularity is dominated by a small minority

The top 524 retained records (approximately 1%) account for 39.6% of all ratings. Total rating counts are strongly right-skewed, so medians and logarithmic plots are more informative than averages alone.



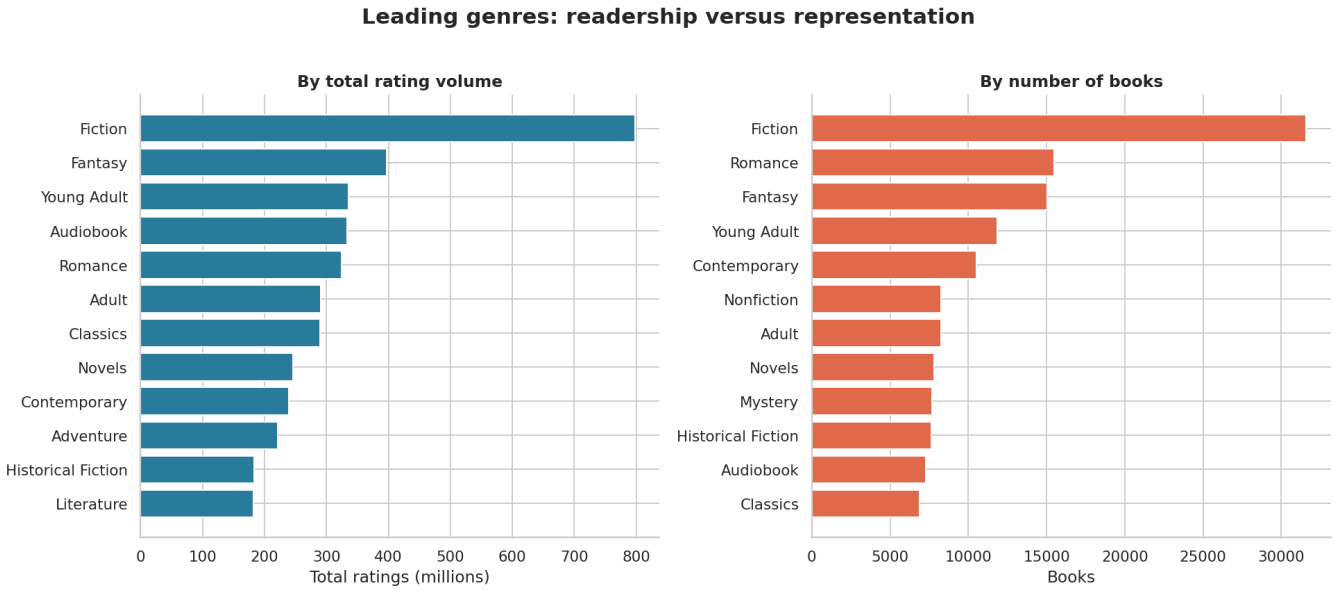
Established authors dominate total readership

J.K. Rowling leads with 24.44 million ratings across 25 retained records, followed by Stephen King (13.01 million) and Suzanne Collins (11.84 million). These totals combine readership per record and number of records; they are not unique-reader counts.



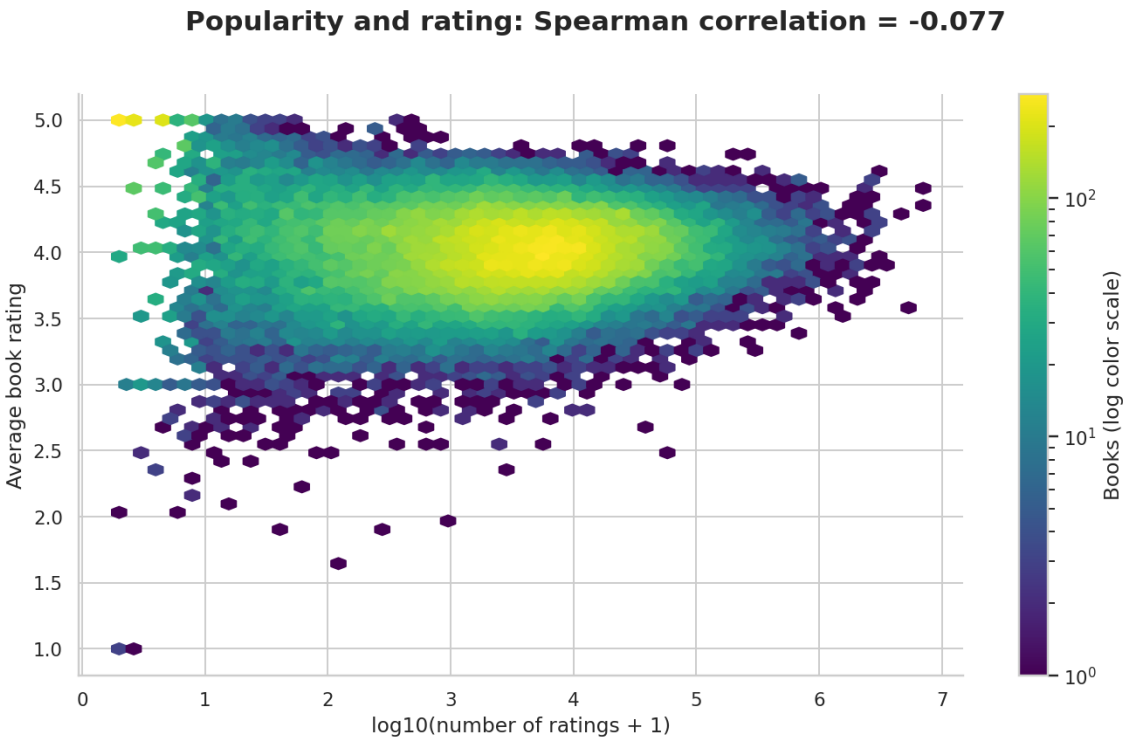
Fiction, fantasy and young adult lead rating volume

Fiction accounts for 797.57 million rating incidences, fantasy 396.73 million, and young adult 335.33 million. Fiction, romance and fantasy lead by number of records. Labels overlap, and tags such as Audiobook describe a format rather than a literary genre; these totals must not be added together.



High popularity does not guarantee a high rating

The overall Spearman correlation is -0.077, a very weak association. Restricting the analysis to at least 1,000 ratings changes it to +0.060, still very weak. The sign is not robust to excluding small samples. Twilight has 4.96 million ratings but a 3.60 average.



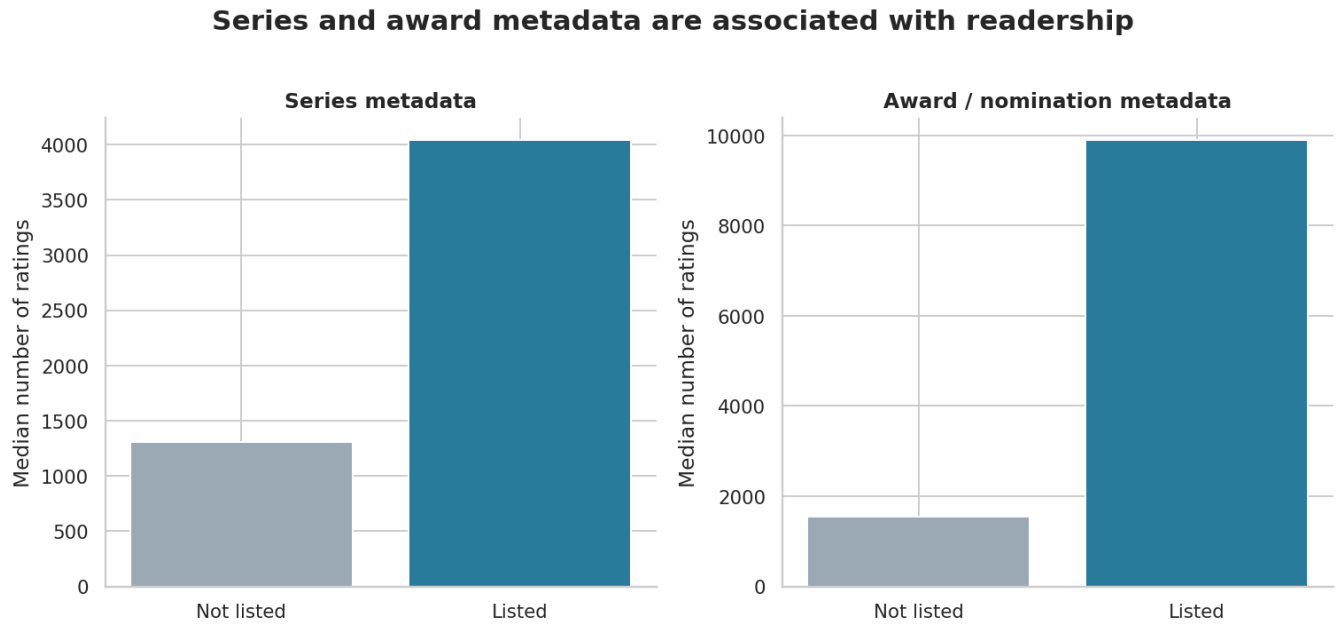
Perfect scores are entirely a small-sample phenomenon here

All 844 records rated exactly 5.0 have at most 36 ratings. Books with 1,000 or more ratings average 4.004. Requiring substantial rating counts is essential when identifying highly rated books; 1,000 is a transparent sensitivity threshold, not a statistical guarantee.



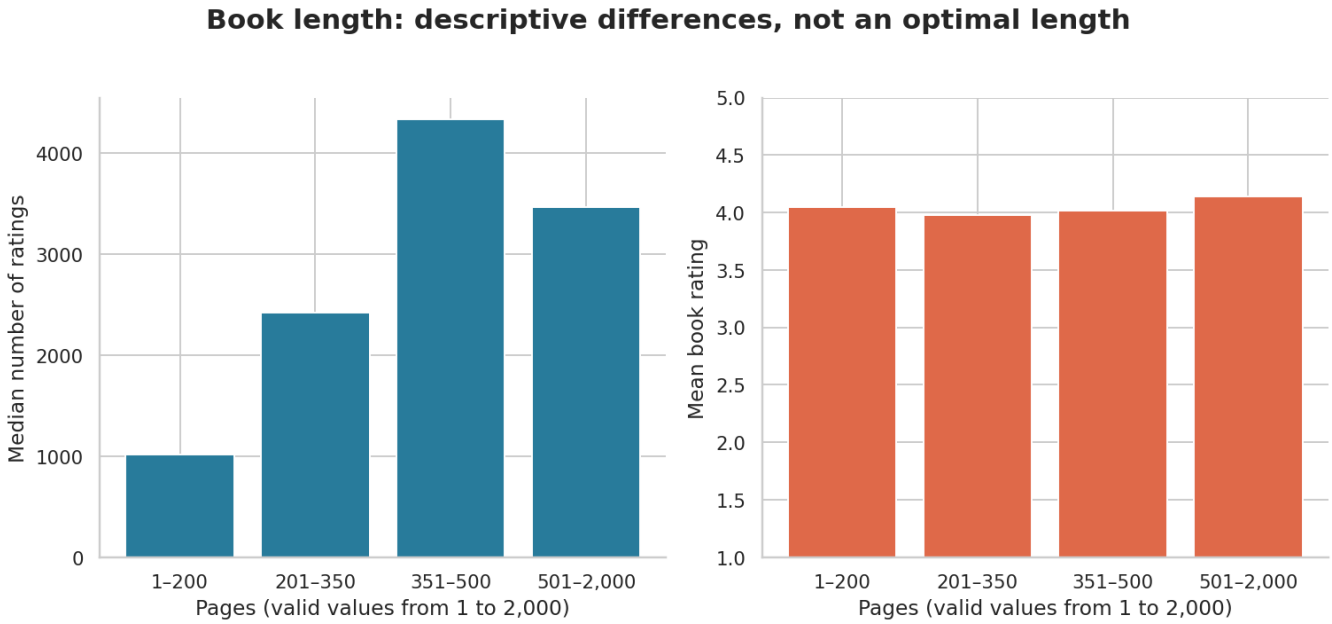
Series and award metadata align with reach, not equally with scores

Series-listed records have a median 4,038.5 ratings versus 1,311 when no series is listed (3.08x), and mean scores of 4.055 versus 4.004. Award/nomination-listed records have a median 9,893 versus 1,540 ratings (6.42x), but lower mean scores: 3.985 versus 4.038. Awards and nominations are combined in this field; missing metadata does not prove absence.



Additional exploration: book length

For valid lengths between 1 and 2,000 pages, median rating counts are 1,019 (1-200 pages), 2,419.5 (201-350), 4,330 (351-500) and 3,461.5 (501-2,000). Corresponding mean scores are 4.046, 3.975, 4.014 and 4.142. The pattern is not monotonic and can reflect genre, series and audience differences; it does not identify an optimal length. The 1-2,000 restriction applies only to this chart.



Limits and next steps

This is a selected Best Books Ever sample, not a random sample of Goodreads. There is no verified collection date, temporal history, sales data, promotion data or reader demographics. Rating counts can overlap across editions and readers. Descriptive group differences are unadjusted and cannot establish causation. A stronger follow-up would validate work identifiers and publication years, define a supported high-rating threshold, and use held-out multivariable models controlling for genre, author and publication age. Feature importance would remain predictive rather than causal.